

Chapter 3: Under What Conditions Were Classical Empires Formed?

Although I observed long ago that a certain type of regime appearing in history could be classified as classical empires, this was merely a categorization of facts. However, just as universal outcomes deserve universal explanations, since classical empires emerged universally across such vast temporal and spatial spans, this implies a high probability of a universal underlying cause. We cannot simply discuss individually how the Persians, Romans, Han Chinese, Magadhans, and Khmers each established an empire.

Yet, in late November, I suddenly realized several critical issues. When I was in school, the official political theory consistently emphasized that "*the state is a tool for the ruling class to exercise rule*" and "*the state serves the interests of the ruling class.*" Such viewpoints unquestionably stem from Marx and Engels, the two communist mentors and founders of scientific socialism.

But this raises a question: if state policies are to reflect the overall interests of the ruling *class* (阶级), this actually requires a certain degree of political democracy—democracy *within* the ruling class, of course. Since the ruling class inevitably consists of more than one person, individual dictatorship would be curbed by the ruling class participating in politics.

Consequently, scholars quickly noticed a specific historical phase—namely, the period after the end of the Middle Ages and before the modern era. During this period, a large number of despotic regimes emerged worldwide, with the power of monarchs expanding unprecedentedly compared to the past. These regimes are classified as Absolutist states (i.e., *absolute monarchies* / 绝对君主制), typified by France under Bourbon rule.

If we turn our gaze to Asia, the Tokugawa Shogunate (德川幕府)—which the Japanese refer to as an **early modern state** (近世国家)—clearly belongs to the same typology. Just like the Bourbon dynasty, the Tokugawa Shogunate even adopted measures to permanently concentrate regional lords in the capital or its outskirts, distancing them from their fiefs to strengthen centralization. (*By that time, I had explicitly realized that China's development had diverged completely from the West since at least the Tang Dynasty. Therefore, although the Ming and Qing dynasties appeared at first glance to be despotic empires, I could deduce that they could no longer be classified as Absolutist states*).

The most successful explanation for the universal causes of Absolutist states was provided by Engels. In *The Origin of the Family, Private Property and the State* (《家庭、私有制和国家的起源》), he pointed out that when the status of two successive ruling classes undergoes a transition, the government—especially the monarch at its apex—will possess the ability to balance between the old and new classes, thereby vastly expanding despotic power and strengthening centralization.

The process of ruling class transition is essentially one where a new *production mode* (生产方式) and mode of exploitation (if any) gradually surpass the old ones in efficiency (i.e., profitability). The old ruling class partially loses its original advantages and partially transforms into the new ruling class; simultaneously, some members who originally did not belong to the ruling class elevate themselves into the new ruling class.

Western scholars have already provided rather detailed explanations regarding the situation of Absolutist states in Europe, making further elaboration completely unnecessary. But what if we

push Engels' explanation of Absolutist states—which clearly emerged during the power transition period between feudal lords and the urban bourgeoisie—back by one historical epoch?

According to the official historiographical periodization our country learned from the Soviet Union's Stalin, the preceding transition should be the transition from the ruling class of a *slavery society* (奴隶制社会) to the ruling class of a **feudal society** (封建社会). But Stalin was obviously not a professional historian, and the richness of historical research back then cannot be compared to today. Now we know that the type of *slavery society* imagined by the Soviet Bolsheviks—a society consisting of nothing but slaveholders and slaves—did not actually exist.

In many regimes prior to the formation of classical empires—such as the Greek city-states, the vassal states of the Spring and Autumn period, Babylon, and Egypt—there were many other people (most typically freemen / 自由民) living outside the binary identities of slaveholder and slave. Some engaged in commercial trade, some in handicrafts, and some were simply independent farmers, and so on.

However, this crude categorization was not entirely wrong in one regard: although the social structures of those regimes once considered *slavery societies* were in reality much more complex, their primary forms of exploitation were indeed bodily possession (人身占有) and forced labor. In other words, for those who were exploited, the vast majority were exploited in the form of "slavery."

Actually, the Chinese historiographical community are not fools either. They realized long ago that the slavery period was clearly more complex. Therefore, when I was in school, if the unification by the Qin Dynasty was mentioned, Chinese historiography generally referred to the opposing side as the *old nobility* (旧贵族) rather than constantly emphasizing their slaveholder attributes (*though propaganda works during the Mao era emphasized this heavily*), having them appear in the narrative as evil villains opposing the righteous First Emperor.

At present, a rather compromised and rational narrative is that prior to the birth of classical empires, there indeed existed such a ruling *class* (阶级) within state regimes. They developed either from the chieftains of tribal clans, from the *priestly class* (祭司阶级) presiding over religious ceremonies, or from military leaders born out of warfare. Together, they formed an aristocratic group within the state, possessing the divine aura of bloodlines and a hereditary ruling status.

Under the social conditions of that time, if this segment of the aristocracy wished to operate industries and expand their wealth, the most efficient method was undoubtedly to become major slaveholders.

As *productive forces* (生产力) continued to improve, social division of labor became more complex, and the influence of city-states surpassed that of the past. These aristocrats began to lose their monopoly over labor and the means of production (especially technology brought about by knowledge). They first lost their economic advantages, and subsequently lost their original political dominance.

In fact, when we observe Chinese history, it is exceedingly easy to notice this **class substitution** (阶级更替)—that is, the transition between the *old nobility* (旧贵族) and the **feudal landlord class** (封建地主阶级).

A most universally known example is the so-called "Hundred Schools of Thought" (诸子百家). In Chinese history, this term broadly refers to the scholars and doctrines of numerous different schools during the Spring and Autumn and Warring States periods. The vast majority of the famous figures among them were descendants of these aristocrats, including Confucius (孔子), Guanzi (管子), Yanzi (晏子), Mencius (孟子), Han Fei (韩非), Shang Yang (商鞅), Mozi (墨子), Sun Wu (孙武), Sun Bin (孙臏), and Xunzi (荀子).

Simultaneously, we can also easily point out many thinkers and politicians who were not descendants of the aristocracy. Some of them even came from humble origins, including Zhuangzi (庄子), Huizi (惠子), Fan Li (范蠡), Su Qin (苏秦), and Zhang Yi (张仪). Although Lü Buwei (吕不韦) was allegedly the 23rd-generation descendant of Jiang Taigong (姜太公), he essentially entered officialdom by virtue of being an immensely wealthy *merchant* (商人).

By the Han Dynasty, thinkers primarily emerged from the newly rising landlord class, represented by Dong Zhongshu (董仲舒), Yang Xiong (扬雄), and others. (*This, of course, is also related to the fact that the pre-Qin aristocracy was massively annihilated during the wars at the end of the Qin Dynasty*).

If we shift our focus of observation from thinkers to politicians, this transition occurred even earlier. After all, the prerequisite for becoming a thinker is possessing a sufficient reserve of knowledge, which in the past was naturally monopolized by the aristocracy. Even something as seemingly simple today as writing was accessible only to the aristocracy and a small number of scribes. Although the popularization of knowledge and education occurred during the Spring and Autumn and Warring States periods, it naturally possessed a certain time lag. Consequently, the identity of the officials responsible for practical affairs would complete this transition even earlier.

Now we can see from Chinese historical facts exactly how classical empires were formed.

When the economic and political status of the *old nobility* was successively weakened, it became difficult for them to maintain their previous privileged position of "*punishments do not extend up to the Grandees*" (刑不上大夫) vis-à-vis the vassal lords. Therefore, the outstanding individuals among the aristocracy and their descendants would seek to utilize their remaining advantages—namely, their grasp of advanced knowledge and political affairs—to enter the courts of the vassal kings and become bureaucrats in order to realize their ambitions.

As for the "new nobility" (新贵 / nouveaux riches) produced amidst social transformation—including newly rising landlords and shrewdly operating large merchants—seizing state power through armed struggle was still far too remote a prospect for them back then. The simplest way to expand their power and influence was also to join the courts of the vassal kings.

For the vassal king, he evidently welcomed this phenomenon as well. This meant that the monarch could easily counterbalance his ministers, rather than being checked by an aristocratic block possessing unified interests.

Simultaneously, the scrambling of both the old and new ruling classes to join the monarch's court allowed the monarch's bureaucratic ranks to expand unprecedentedly. This further strengthened the state's degree of centralization and the monarch's despotic power.

It was precisely this transformation that impelled the vassal kingdoms to launch annexation wars of ever-increasing scale, and allowed one of these regimes to overwhelm all others, ruling over a

massive territory that predecessors had never managed to control. Thus, the classical empire was born.

The advantage of this explanation is that it not only maintains consistency with Western scholars' explanations of Absolutist states, but it is also exquisitely validated in the history of China.

The political reforms and centralization of the Qin state were inextricably linked to these bureaucrats who originated either from the old nobility or the newly emerged classes. The reason Qin had the opportunity to go further than other vassal states is attributed to a cliché often cited by historians: namely, Qin was adept at utilizing the *scholar-officials* (士人 / literati) from the other six states.

Although Qin was merely one of the seven major vassal states prior to unification, it managed to attract talent from the other six states who sought to make a mark for themselves. The emergence of this situation cannot simply be summarized by historical texts claiming that the monarchs of Qin were sagacious and cherished talent; it was clearly closely related to the actual conditions of the Qin state back then.

For instance, the economic and social development of the Qin region was relatively backward compared to the six eastern states. When drastic class upheavals in the six states produced a massive number of unattached scholar-officials wandering among the vassal kingdoms, such transformations had not occurred domestically within Qin. Consequently, the rulers of Qin naturally tended to recruit foreign scholar-officials, which served their own interests.

Additionally, during the final period of the Warring States era, the Qin state exhibited a highly significant political characteristic: its imperial relatives by marriage (外戚 / consort kin) hailed from foreign aristocracies and were politically immensely influential. Naturally, it was impossible for them to be entirely on harmonious terms with Qin's indigenous aristocracy. Thus, drawing in scholar-officials who similarly hailed from foreign states to serve as external support was perfectly normal.

However, the monarchs of Qin, especially Qin Shi Huang (秦始皇 / the First Emperor), completely failed to comprehend why the Qin state was able to establish an extractive system vastly more powerful than other nations. The Qin Empire conquered and annihilated the remaining six major vassal states in a mere nine years; its limited bureaucracy was fundamentally insufficient to support rule over such a massive expanse.

Consequently, as the situation deteriorated, Qin Shi Huang could only resort to increasingly brutal suppression. Yet the harsher the suppression, the more unwilling the intellectuals of the conquered regions were to cooperate, prompting them to seek the restoration of their former states. The situation then deteriorated further. The rapid demise of the Qin Dynasty is therefore utterly unsurprising.

After Liu Bang established the Han Dynasty, he absorbed the lesson of Qin's rapid demise. He vastly contracted the territories the empire needed to rule directly, and effectively restored the vassal kingdoms in the Guandong (关东) region—only now, these vassal kings were all royal kinsmen of the Liu clan. As China largely stabilized and production further developed, the Han Empire was able to move forward along the conventional historical trajectory of classical empires.

Only by this time, the professional bureaucrats joining the imperial court were no longer the old nobility, who had already been massively annihilated. Famous ministers of the early Han, such as Jia Yi (贾谊) and Chao Cuo (晁错), although their exact origins are not explicitly recorded, largely belonged to the newly rising landlord class.

By the time Emperor Wu ascended the throne, the situation shifted again. This touches upon a historical controversy in Chinese history: the issue of the **"Inner Court"** (内朝) during Emperor Wu's reign.

The official explanation claims that Emperor Wu created the Inner Court, where the emperor and his close ministers made decisions, thereby weakening the power of the **"Outer Court"** (外朝—official historiography specifically emphasizes the Chancellor's Office / 丞相府) and enhancing despotic centralization. But this is actually a remarkably clumsy lie.

The Inner Court was not created by Emperor Wu to counterbalance the Outer Court; **it was, in itself, the standard royal court of a classical state. What was genuinely newly emergent was the Outer Court.**

Because the highly developed *bureaucratic system*—established through the reform movements during Emperor Wu's reign—compelled the classical royal court to "cede" a portion of its functions, it shrank back into what is referred to as the "Inner Court". It is fundamentally impossible to draw a clear institutional boundary between the Inner Court and the Outer Court, because the decline of the Han Dynasty's classical royal court and the comprehensive ascendance of the bureaucratic system was inherently a dynamic process.

During Emperor Wu's reign, China's classical society had not yet entirely perished, and he personally always possessed the discernment to recognize talent and the power to appoint personnel. Therefore, the key to judging whether someone originated from the Inner Court lies in observing their promotion trajectory: whether they caught the emperor's attention and received an extraordinary promotion (特擢).

A glaringly obvious fact is that it was precisely the Inner Court officials during Emperor Wu's reign, along with those dispatched from the Inner Court to the Outer Court (like Sang Hongyang), who conformed to the bureaucratic political operations of a typical classical empire. That is to say, the monarch did not select officials according to a mature set of selection rules, but relied on intuition and personal preference to appoint people from vastly different backgrounds to serve as advisors or top provincial officials. **Whether unintentionally or deliberately, this achieved a counterbalance among various social strata, thereby allowing the monarch's power to expand.**

If we observe those close ministers during Emperor Wu's reign, we will find that their identities varied wildly. Han Yan (韩嫣) was a descendant of the monarch of the Han state; Ji An's (汲黯) family had served as officials for generations; Kong Anguo (孔安国) was a descendant of Confucius; Sang Hongyang hailed from a merchant background; Ni Kuan (倪宽) came from a poor family; Bu Shi made his living through animal husbandry; Wei Qing was originally a riding slave; Huo Qubing was already a member of the consort kin when promoted; Huo Guang entered officialdom through hereditary privilege (恩荫); Shangguan Jie (上官桀) gained appreciation as an imperial guard officer; Jin Midi (金日磾) was even a surrendered Xiongnu prince.

Many of these identities were actually despised by the mainstream social opinion of the time. For example, although the romance between Sima Xiangru (司马相如) and his wife Zhuo Wenjun is praised today, he was after all suspected of building his fortune using his father-in-law's wealth. As for merchants and slaves, it goes without saying.

The ideological and political leanings of these Inner Court officials were equally disparate. For instance, Bu Shi and Sang Hongyang stood in absolute opposition; Ji An adhered to the Huang-Lao (黄老之学 / Daoist) school; Zhang Tang (张汤) leaned toward Legalist methods and punishments (刑名法术); Ni Kuan, although a Confucian, studied the Old Text (古文经学) rather than the orthodox New Text (今文经学) of the time. Sima Qian, although acknowledging Confucianism, held views wildly divergent from the emperor's. There were even more various *Fangshi* (方士 / alchemists and esoteric practitioners) belonging to the Yin-Yang school. As for someone like Dongfang Shuo (东方朔), his ideas were so unconstrained and eccentric that one simply could not pin down which school he belonged to.

These bizarre heretics within the court were not only not prohibited, but were even permitted and supported in disseminating their own ideologies. For instance, Kong Anguo taught Old Text Confucianism while serving as an official. The Old and New Text schools coexisted peacefully throughout Emperor Wu's reign, but became the central topic of political struggle in the late Western Han—a protracted debate that was only finally resolved by the evidential research scholars (*Kaoju* scholars / 考据学家) of the Qing Dynasty.

Another major feature of the Inner Court was that, under the emperor's encouragement and support, a vast amount of literary and artistic creation took place. Sima Xiangru developed the Han *Fu* (汉赋 / Han rhapsody) to maturity; Sima Qian wrote the immortal *Records of the Grand Historian*; Yu Chu wrote China's first novel, the *Zhou Shuo* (《周说》); Li Yannian (李延年) composed and adapted numerous musical pieces; and even the *Cuju Jing* (《蹴鞠经》 / *Classic of Cuju* [ancient Chinese football]) was born during Emperor Wu's reign—even a specialized work on kicking a ball was published.

Emperor Wu himself was full of enthusiasm for such vibrant cultural creation and sponsored it unsparingly. He was an outstanding poet and literatus himself, ranking among the top Chinese rulers in history regarding his massive contributions to arts and literature.

Actually, it is not difficult to discover that these attendants of Emperor Wu, rather than being called close ministers, are often better described as *Menke* (门客 / retainers or guest-scholars) reminiscent of the Warring States and early Qin-Han periods. A court with such a complex source of personnel, such ideological pluralism (百花齐放), and such intensely active creation never appeared again from the time of his death right up to the last emperor of the Qing Dynasty.

This further reflects the fact that the **classical state** (古典国家), in the general sense, terminated precisely during Emperor Wu's reign. That is to say, the so-called Inner Court was itself the result of the inward shrinking of the late Warring States to early Han style court—the classical Chinese royal court. Its mode of operation actually conformed to the general laws of historical development.

In contrast, an Outer Court with a unified ideology and an institutionalized system for official selection and promotion was the true anomaly in historical development; it was the genuine "newcomer." How, then, could it be a case of "using the Inner Court to control the Outer Court"?

Another very direct piece of evidence is that after Emperor Wu, the Inner Court actually continued to shrink and eventually disappeared, rather than expanding. After Huo Guang's (霍光) death, there was never again a team with such diverse origins, active thinking, and decisive power surrounding the monarch to assist in state governance (*on the other hand, the need to cope with a multitude of internal and external affairs, as in Emperor Wu's reign, no longer existed either*).

And Huo Guang himself, despite holding supreme power, still did not usurp the Liu clan's realm, but dedicated his wisdom and courage to the very end. There was never again a powerful minister quite like him, to the extent that in the eyes of posterity, he is ranked alongside Yi Yin (伊尹) of the Shang Dynasty.

This absolutely cannot be explained by personal morality. In reality, Huo Guang was the last powerful minister under a general-sense classical *bureaucratic system* in Chinese history. The zenith of his power was inextricably bound to the trust and mandate of the imperial family; he could not secure the support of the "**Chinese-style bureaucratic system**" (中式官僚体系) that formed after Emperor Wu.

The heterogeneity of the classical bureaucratic system meant that a powerful minister had to rely on the monarch's authority to hold power, because he would not gain the endorsement of a highly cohesive bureaucratic system sharing identical interests and objectives from top to bottom. Unless he genuinely demonstrated an ability sufficient to awe the entire realm into submission, usurpation was nearly impossible. Thus, not usurping the throne was the rational choice dictated by political structure, not by morality.

Powerful ministers starting from Wang Mang (王莽), however, were able to take over the emperor's control over the bureaucratic system after reaching the pinnacle of officialdom, and seize state power with the support of the bureaucrats. This transformation in circumstances exacerbated the mutual suspicion between monarch and ministers, drastically altering China's political ecology after the Han Dynasty.

By the Eastern Han, although Emperor Guangwu (Liu Xiu) wished to strengthen monarchical power using the *Shangshu Tai* (尚书台 / Imperial Secretariat), the Chinese-style bureaucratic system had already matured over the century since Emperor Wu. The emperor's personal understanding and living environment were also vastly different from the early to mid-Western Han.

At this point, the emperor's so-called "Inner Court" had to rely either on eunuchs (宦官)—who, being physically and personally mutilated, could only attach themselves to the monarch—or on dividing a faction of bureaucrats to act as confidants (*most commonly the empress's family, what Chinese call consort kin / 外戚*). After all, these monarchs were surrounded by professional bureaucrats from their youth. This was a far cry from the classical bureaucratic system in the general sense, and in terms of efficacy, it was extremely difficult to achieve the purpose of strengthening monarchical power.

A genuinely significant political emergence of "using the Inner to control the Outer" (以内制外) should not be dated earlier than the Southern Dynasties period. Its hallmark should be the phenomenon of "*scholars from humble origins managing confidential state affairs*" (寒门掌机要) during the Liu Song (刘宋) period. Interestingly, the monarch who exerted the greatest influence on political systemic change at that time was also surnamed Liu, and shared the exact same

posthumous title with Liu Che: "Xiaowu" (孝武). However, these are matters for later, to be specifically researched in the future.

Finally, it must be pointed out that the political policies during Emperor Wu's reign and the formation of the Chinese *bureaucratic system* (官僚体制) were, initially, highly conducive to **feudalization** (封建化). This encompasses at least three points.

First, Emperor Wu himself ruthlessly struck out against the remnants of the *slavery system* during his reign. We do not even need to concern ourselves with his personal ideological leanings. The sheer fact that male and female slaves (奴婢) were universally present within the empire (*there is currently no precise estimate, but if I take a median value, it would be 1/10 of the total population*) was highly detrimental to the empire's ability to mobilize more manpower and wealth for military and other purposes.

Leaving aside the fact that slavery becomes an inefficient mode of production and exploitation once *productive forces* reach a certain level, many slaves were not even used for productive purposes but purely for elite enjoyment.

Thus, we can observe that during Emperor Wu's reign, numerous measures were taken regarding the slave issue. First, shortly after ascending the throne, he pardoned a group of people who had been relegated to slavery because they were implicated in the Rebellion of the Seven States (*naturally, this was more of a political posture*). Then, he hoped that powerful families and wealthy households would voluntarily hand over their slaves to the court in exchange for becoming Gentlemen of the Palace (郎官), but this obviously attracted very few people.

Consequently, Emperor Wu decided to employ heavy-handed methods directly against those guys who "*refuse to assist the state in its emergencies*" (不佐国家之急). Through the implementation of *Suanmin* (算缗 / property tax on merchants) and *Gaomin* (告缗 / encouraging the reporting of tax evasion), he bankrupted almost all the wealthy households nationwide and confiscated tens of thousands of slaves.

Lastly, the court also did not want slaves to be arbitrarily killed by their masters simply because they had absolutely no legal status, as this too destroyed *productive forces*. Dong Zhongshu had once proposed that those who privately killed slaves must also be punished (*Treatise on Food and Money* / 《食货志》). Factually speaking, Emperor Wu indeed accepted this advice, because the earliest records in our country of treating the private killing of slaves as a punishable crime appeared during his reign (*Table of the Princes Made Marquises* / 《王子侯表》 & *Table of Those Made Marquises Since the Jianyuan Era* / 《建元以来侯者年表》).

Of course, one cannot assume that all these slaves confiscated by the government were emancipated into independent farmers. In reality, the *Treatise on Food and Money* records that the majority were dispatched to serve the government. However, this attitude of publicly curbing the keeping of slaves was undoubtedly a deterrent to those hoping to purchase them.

Second, agricultural production experienced tremendous progress during Emperor Wu's reign. Its iconic achievement was the popularization of iron tools and ox-drawn plows across China, while water conservancy irrigation and planting methods were also drastically improved.

Today, we can no longer accurately determine exactly how much China's agricultural yield per *mu* increased before and after Emperor Wu, because data prior to his reign is exceedingly scarce. Chao

Cuo claimed that an adult laborer could cultivate 100 Han *mu* (if calculated by the small *mu*, this equates to 14-15 modern Chinese *mu*).

From scattered descriptions of fields in the *Treatise on Rivers and Canals* (《河渠书》) and the *Biographies of the Money-Makers* (《货殖列传》), we can deduce that the yield per *mu* of high-quality land at the time did not exceed 400 *jin* (although Sima Qian did not specify the exact crop). However, in the *Fan Shengzhi Shu* (《汜胜之书》 / *The Book of Fan Shengzhi*) from the late Western Han, the yield per *mu* of broomcorn millet (黍) had already reached 470 *jin*.

Naturally, the specific yields of various crops in the Han Dynasty cannot be verified with absolute precision. Yet we can perceive the agricultural progress of the time from a highly indirect angle: during Emperor Wu's reign, the empire's population was only slightly over 30 million; but by the end of the Western Han Dynasty, it had nearly doubled, reaching 60 million. The elevation of agricultural *productive forces* clearly favored the development of the small-peasant economy and strengthened the economic power of the newly rising **feudal landlord class**.

Third, a comprehensive and mature *bureaucratic system* could provide the landlord class with a more convenient avenue to enter officialdom. Therefore, compared to typical classical bureaucratic empires, the Western Han Empire could absorb the landlord class into political decision-making much faster and in vastly greater numbers, which in turn further augmented the strength of the landlord class.

In fact, we can distinctly see that among the various classical empires, China's classical period was actually remarkably short. From Emperor Wu basically finalizing the institutional framework to the mid-Eastern Han, feudal manors (封建庄园) had already become extremely prevalent nationwide. Only two centuries had passed during that time! And by the late Eastern Han, feudal relations had become exceedingly widespread (*though immature*); subordinate officials (掾属) of high-ranking regional administrators referred to their superiors as "Lord" (主公). This took a mere 300 years!

Such a rapid transition was something Rome, Persia, and other nations could not even begin to compare with.

However, it was precisely because the Chinese landlord class stepped onto the historical stage so effortlessly—without undergoing brutal struggles—that it inevitably engendered a kind of weakness (软弱性), a propensity for compromise (妥协性), and an ideological inertia (思想上的惯性). Ultimately, as a causal factor, this led to the result that although China entered the track of feudalization earliest, it never reached the finish line.

At this point, people will certainly still harbor doubts regarding whether it is rational to define classical empires as the transitional political system from *slavery states* (if such a term is appropriate) to feudal states. After all, it is only within Chinese literature that considerably explicit evidence exists.

Regarding this issue, I believe that, on the one hand, the volume of historical literature from our country's *pre-feudalization* (前封建化) period is extraordinarily abundant compared to the same period in other parts of the world. It is entirely possible that the exact same phenomenon existed elsewhere in the world, but was simply not recorded or the texts have been lost.

On the other hand, the reason this transition became so glaringly obvious in China—while perhaps inherently less pronounced elsewhere—stems from specific causes. I will mention these differences respectively in various subsequent sections and provide a concentrated explanation in Chapter XII.

And just like that, the universal causes for classical empires have been provided, and the historical record regarding the nature of the Inner Court during Emperor Wu's reign has been set straight (拨乱).

Simultaneously, however, I grew increasingly apprehensive. I increasingly felt that Chinese history is saturated with lies, and that these lies appear so pervasively in the education of the people.

If these lies are unintentional, then what exactly has our country's historiography been researching for the past thousands of years? If some of these lies are intentional, then the situation is even more terrifying: **who is trying to cover up what?**

Regardless, by late November, my anxiety had indeed deepened, and this anxiety was about to become reality.

三，古典帝国是在什么条件下形成的

虽然很早之前我就观察到可以把历史上出现的一类政权归为古典帝国，但是这仅仅是一种对事实的分类。不过就如同普遍性的结果应该得到普遍性的解释一样，既然古典帝国在时空差距如此大的范围内普遍出现，这就意味着极大概率会存在着一个普遍性的原因，而不能只去分别论述波斯人，罗马人，汉人，摩揭陀人和高棉人是怎么建立一个帝国的。在 11 月末我突然意识到了一些关键的问题，我上学的时候官方的政治理论一直强调“国家是统治阶级进行统治的工具”和“国家为统治阶级的利益服务”，这样的观点毫无疑问来自马克思、恩格斯两位共产主义导师，科学社会主义的创始人。但这样就牵扯到一个问题，如果国家的政策要反映统治阶级的整体利益，那这事实上就要求存在一定程度上的政治民主，当然是统治阶级间的民主。既然统治阶级必不可能只有一个人，那么个人的独裁就会被参与政治的统治阶级所遏制。于是学者很快就注意到了一个特殊的历史阶段，也就是中世纪结束之后，现代之前的时期，这一时期世界范围内出现了一大批专制政权，君主的权力相对于以往空前扩大，这些政权被归类为绝对主义国家，以波旁王朝统治的法国为典型。我们把目光转向亚洲，那么日本人称为近世国家的德川幕府显然也属于同一类型，甚至德川幕府与波旁王朝一样采取了将各地领主长期集中到首都或近郊使其远离封地来加强中央集权的措施。（那个时候我已经明确意识到，至少从唐朝开始中国的发展就完全不同于西方，因而虽然明清乍看起来也是专制帝国，但我能猜到明清已经不可能是绝对主义国家了）

解释绝对主义国家的普遍成因最为成功的还是恩格斯，他在《家庭、私有制和国家的起源》中指出当前后两个统治阶级的地位发生交替时，政府特别是位于其顶点的君主将有能力在新旧阶级之间进行平衡，从而大大扩张专制权力并加强中央集权。统治阶级交替的过程，本质上是新的生产和剥削（如果有）方式在效率上（也就是收益上）逐渐超过旧的生产和剥削（如果有）方式，旧有统治阶级部分丧失其原有优势，部分转化成为新统治阶级，同时还有一些原本不属于统治阶级的成员跻身为新的统治阶级。关于欧洲绝对主义国家的情况西方学者已经做出了比较详尽的解释，完全没必要赘述。但是如果我们把恩格斯关于绝对主义国家的解释（显然绝对主义出现在封建领主和城市资产阶级进行权力更迭的时期）向上再推一个时代呢？按照我国从苏联斯大林那里学到的官方史学划分，上一次更迭应当为奴隶制社会的统治阶级向封建社会的统治阶级过渡。但是斯大林显然不是一个专业的历史学家，而且那个时候历史研究的丰富度也不能跟今天比，现在我们已经知道不存在苏联布尔什维克想象的那种奴隶制社会，也就是除了奴隶主就是奴隶的社会。古典帝国形成前的很多政权，例如希腊的城邦，春秋时期的诸侯国，巴比伦和埃及，在奴隶主和奴隶两种身份以外还有很多其他人（最典型的是自由民）在生活，有的从事商业贸易，有的从事手工业，有的就是自耕农等等。但是这种粗暴的划分有一点倒是没有完全错误，那就是尽管那些曾经被认为是奴隶制社会的政权实际上的社会结构要复杂很多，但是其主要的剥削形式的确是人身占有和强迫劳动，也就是说对于被剥削的人而言，他们绝大部分都是以“奴隶制”的形式被剥削。

实际上中国的史学界也不是傻瓜，他们早就意识到奴隶制时期显然更为复杂，所以在我上学的时候如果提到秦朝的统一，中国的史学界一般将对立的一方称为“旧贵族”而已经不是总强调其奴隶主的属性了（但是毛时期的宣传作品非常强调这一点），作为和正义的始皇帝相对抗的邪恶反派出现在叙事中。

目前看来比较折中和合理的叙述是，在古典帝国诞生之前的国家政权中确实存在这样一个统治阶级，他们或者由氏族部落的首领发展而来，或者由主持宗教仪式的祭司发展而来，或者由战争中诞生的军事领袖发展而来，形成了一个国家中的贵族群体具有血缘的神性和身份上的世袭的统治地位。而在当时的社会条件下，如果这一部分贵族想要经营产业并且扩大自己的财富，最具效率的方式当然就是成为大奴隶主。当生产力继续提高，社会分工变得更加复杂，城邦的影响力超过以往，这些贵族开始失去对劳动力以及生产资料（特别是知识带来的技术）的垄断地位，他们首先在经济上失去优势，然后就是在政治上丧失原有的统治力。实际上当我们观察中国的历史的时候，就非常容易注意到这种阶级交替，也就是旧贵族和封建地主阶级之间的更迭。一个最众所周知的例子就是所谓的诸子百家，这在中国历史上被用来泛指春秋战国时期众多不同学派的学者和学说，而其中大部分名人都是这些贵族的后代，包括孔子，管子，晏子，孟子，韩非，商鞅，墨子，孙武，孙臆，荀子。同时我们也能够很容易指出许多不出于贵族后代的思想家和政治家们，他们有些甚至出身低微，包括庄子，惠子，范蠡，苏秦，张仪等，吕不韦虽然据称是姜太公的23世孙，但本质上也是以商人巨富进入仕途。等到汉代，思想家们已经大多出于新兴的地主阶级了，以董仲舒、扬雄等为代表（这当然也跟秦以前的贵族的秦末战争中被大量消灭有关）。

如果我们把观察的目的从思想家转向政治家，那么这种过渡发生得更早，毕竟成为思想家的前提本身就是有够多的知识储备，而这在以前当然是受贵族垄断的，即使是书写这样现在看来简单的事情除了贵族也只有少数书吏能接触。知识和教育的普及虽然在春秋战国时期发生了，但是当然会具有一定的滞后性，而负责实际事务的官吏的身份就会更早完成这种过渡。现在我们就能够从中国的历史事实中看出古典帝国是怎么形成的，当旧贵族的经济地位和政治地位被相继削弱之后，其便很难维持之前与诸侯国君保持一种“刑不上大夫”的特权地位，因此贵族及其后人中的佼佼者就会设法利用他们尚存的优势，也就是对高级知识和政治事务的了解进入诸侯王的宫廷当中成为一名官僚以实现其抱负。而对于社会变革中产生的“新贵”，包括新兴地主和善于经营的大商人来说，在当年通过武装斗争获取政权还太过遥远，扩大自己权势和影响力的最简单办法也是加入诸侯王的宫廷。对于诸侯王而言，他显然也欢迎这种现象，这意味着君主可以轻易地制衡大臣，而不是被一个有着统一利益的贵族团体所制衡。与此同时新旧两拨统治阶级争相加入君主的宫廷也使得君主能够拥有的官僚队伍空前扩大了，这进一步加强了国家的集权程度和君主的专制权力。正是这种变化促使了诸侯王国得以发动规模越来越大的兼并战争，并且使得其中一个政权压倒了其他所有政权统治了前人从来没有控制过的庞大疆域，古典帝国就这样诞生了。这种解释的好处在于它不但与西方学者在对绝对主义国家的解释保持一贯性，而且在中国的历史上得到了非常好地验证。

秦国的变法和集权离不开这些出身于旧贵族或出身于新阶级的官僚，而秦之所以有机会比其他诸侯国走得更远则归功于历史学家老生常谈的一点，也就是秦善用六国士人。秦虽然在统一前只是七个主要诸侯国之一，却能够吸引其余六国希望出人头地的人才为其效力。这种情况的产生绝不仅仅是史书说的秦朝国君贤明爱才就能概括的，它显然与一些秦国当年的实际情况密切相关，例如秦地的经济社会发展相对落后于东方六国，当六国剧烈的阶级变动产生了大量游走于诸侯之间的士人时，秦国国内却没有发生这种变化，因而秦国统治者有利于自己的目的自然倾向于招揽外国士人。另外秦国在战国的最后一段时期存在一个很重要的政治特征，即外戚出自外国贵族并且在政治上极具影响力，他们当然不可能不与秦国本土的贵族其乐融融，那么将同样出身外国的士人引为奥援再正常不过了。然而秦国国君尤其是秦始皇根本无法理解为什么秦国能够建立起一套远比其他国家有力的榨取制度，秦帝国在短短九年中攻灭了剩下六个大诸侯国，有限的官僚根本不足以支持在这么大的范围内统治。于是局势越糜烂，秦始皇就只能以更为残暴的态度进行弹压，而越是弹压，被征服地区的知识分子就越不愿意合作并且谋求复国，局势就更加糜烂，秦朝的快速灭亡是毫不值得奇怪的事。

刘邦建立汉朝之后吸了秦朝速亡的教训，大大收缩了帝国需要直接统治的疆域，而在事实上恢复了关东的诸侯王国，只不过这些诸侯王现在都是刘氏的宗亲。随着中国在大体上安定下来和生产的进一步发展，汉帝国得以沿着古典帝国常规的历史进程向前运动，只是到了这个时候加入帝国宫廷的职业官僚就已经不是被大面积消灭的旧贵族了，汉初的名臣比如贾谊、晁错等虽未明确记载出身，但大抵都为新兴的地主阶级。及至武帝践祚，情况又发生了变化，这涉及中国历史上的一个公案，也就是汉武帝时期

“内朝”的问题。官方的解释是汉武帝时期创制内朝，在内朝中皇帝及其近臣进行决策，从而削弱了外朝（官方史学特别强调丞相府）的权力，增强了专制主义中央集权，但这其实是非常拙劣的谎言。内朝不是汉武帝创造出来制衡外朝的，它本身就是一般古典国家的宫廷，真正新出现的是外朝。因为武帝统治时期更化运动而建立起的发达官僚体制使得古典宫廷“让渡”出了部分职能，回缩成为所谓的“内朝”。内朝和外朝根本不可能进行制度上的明确划分，因为汉代古典宫廷的衰退以及官僚体制的全面得势本身就是一个动态过程。汉武帝在执政时期中国的古典社会还没有完全消亡，他本人也始终具有识人的眼光和用人的权力。因此判断一个人是否出身内朝关键还是看其升迁路线，即是否被皇帝关注并得到特擢。

一个非常明显的事实是，恰恰是汉武帝时期的内朝官以及从内朝派往外朝的官员（例如桑弘羊）才符合一般古典帝国的官僚政治运作，也就是君主不按照一套成熟的选官规则来选拔官员，而是凭借直觉和喜好去任命出身千差万别的人去担任参谋顾问和封疆大吏，无意或者有意地与社会各个阶层间达成一种制衡，使得君主的权力得以扩大。如果我们观察汉武帝时期那些近臣们，就会发现他们的身份千差万别，韩嫣是韩国国君的后人，汲黯家中世代为官，孔安国为孔子之后，桑弘羊出身商贾，倪宽家境贫寒，卜式本事畜牧，卫青原本是骑奴，霍去病被提拔时已经是外戚，霍光恩荫入仕，上官桀以禁军军官受到赏识，金日磾甚至是归降的匈奴王子。这些身份不少都为当时主流的社会意见所恶，例如司马相如与其妻子卓文君的爱情现在虽然为人称道，但毕竟是有利用岳父的财产发家的嫌疑，至于商人和奴仆就更不用说了。内朝官员的思想和政治倾向千差万别，例如卜式和桑弘羊完全对立，汲黯坚持黄老之学，张汤倾向刑名法术，倪宽虽然也是儒者但是却学习古文经学而非当时正统的今文经学，司马迁虽然认可儒学但是观点也与皇帝大相径庭，各种属于阴阳家的方士那就更多了，至于像东方朔这样的人，其思想天马行空，根本说不上是哪一派。

这些宫廷中的奇怪异端非但没有被禁止，甚至还可以被允许和支持传播自己的思想，例如孔安国就边为官边教授古文经学，今古文经学在武帝一朝一直相安无事，但是在西汉后期却成为政坛斗争的中心话题，一直到清朝的考据学家才最终解决这一漫长的争论。内朝的另一个重大特点是在皇帝的鼓励和支持下进行了很多的文学艺术创作，司马相如将汉赋发展到成熟，司马迁写下了不朽的《史记》，虞初写了中国第一本小说《周说》，李延年谱写并翻译了很多乐曲，甚至汉武帝年间还诞生了《蹴鞠经》，连关于踢球都有专门的作品问世。汉武帝本人对于如此活跃的文化创造充满热情并且毫不吝惜地赞助，他自己就是一个杰出的诗人和文学家，在历史上是数一数二的对文艺有巨大贡献的中国统治者。实际上不难发现，汉武帝的这些侍从与其说是近臣，其实很多不如说是战国和秦汉早期的门客。像汉武帝时期这样人员来源复杂，思想上百花齐放，创作极为活跃的宫廷，从他去世之后一直到清朝的最后一个皇帝都再也没有出现过了，这更加反映了一般意义上的古典国家就是在汉武帝时期终止的这个事实。这也就是说，所谓内朝本身就是战国晚期至汉初式的宫廷也就是中国的古典宫廷内缩的结果，它的运作方式反而是符合一般历史发展规律的。

相比之下，一个意识形态统一，存在制度化选官和升迁制度的外朝才是历史发展中的异数，才是真正的“来者”，又怎么以“内朝制外朝”呢？另一个非常直接的证据是，内朝在汉武帝之后实际上是继续萎缩并消失了而非继续扩张。在霍光去世之后，再也没有一个像武帝朝那样来源广泛，思想活跃，决策有力的团队围绕在君主身边辅助国家治理了（另一方面像武帝年间那样应对内外多事的需求也不存在了）。而霍光本人在大权在握的情况下却依旧没有篡夺刘氏的天下而是将其智勇奉献到了最后，再也没有像他这样的权臣，以至于其在后人眼中与商代的伊尹并列。这也绝非是能用个人道德来解释的，实际上霍光是中国历史上最后一个一般意义的古典官僚体制下的权臣，其权力高度与皇室的信任与托付绑定，而无法取得武帝之后形成的“中式官僚体系”的支持。古典官僚体制的混杂性使得权臣必须借助君主的权威才能把持权力，因为他不会得到一个利益和目的高度一致的，从上到下统治国家的官僚体制的认可。除非他真的展示出足以威服天下人的能力，篡位几乎不可能成功，不篡位是合乎常理的选择，这是由政治结构而非道德决定的。自王莽开始的权臣则能够到达人臣的顶点之后接管皇帝对于官僚体制的控制，并在官僚们的支持下夺取政权，这种情况的转变加剧了君主和臣子之间的互相猜疑，使得汉代之后中国的政治生态大为转变。到了东汉，光武帝刘秀虽然想以尚书台来加强君主的权力，但自武帝以后一个世纪间中式官僚体制已经成熟起来，皇帝本人的认识和生活环境也与西汉中前期大为不同。这个时候皇帝所谓的“内朝”要么倚仗于在身体和人格上残缺只能依附于君主的宦官，要么就只能从官僚中分化一部分作为亲信（最常见的就是皇后的家人，也就是中国人说的外戚），毕竟这些君主在年轻的时候就处于

职业官僚的环绕当中，这与一般意义上的古典官僚体制相差甚远，从效果上看也很难达成加强君主权力的作用。而真正意义上的“以内制外”在政治上显著地出现则不应早于南朝时期，其标志应该是刘宋时期的“寒门掌机要”，有意思的是，当时对政治体制变革起到最大影响的君主不但姓刘，而且和刘彻有同一个谥号“孝武”。不过这些都是后话，以后再具体研究。

最后应该指出，汉武帝时期的政治政策和中国官僚体制的形成在最初是很有利于封建化的，这至少包含了三点。

第一，汉武帝本人在他执政期间狠狠打击了奴隶制残余，这都不需要关心他本人的思想倾向，仅仅是帝国内普遍存在的奴婢（现在没有一个准确估计，我取一个中间值也就是总人口的1/10）就非常不利于帝国调动更多的人力和财富用于军事和其他目的。且不说奴隶制在生产达到一定程度之后就是一种低效的生产和剥削方式，而且很多奴隶也不是被用于生产目的而是纯粹的享受。所以我们能看到武帝年间对于奴婢问题采取了很多举措，首先是他刚继位不久就赦免了因为七国之乱中一部分因为受牵连被贬为奴婢的人（当然，这个肯定是政治姿态的成分更多）。然后他希望豪强富户主动能够将自己的奴婢交给朝廷作为回报可以成为郎官，但是显然这没有吸引多少人。于是汉武帝决定对这些“不佐国家之急”的家伙直接用强硬手段，通过算缗和告缗使得全国富户几乎尽数破产，没收了成千上万的奴婢。最后朝廷也不希望奴婢因为其毫无法律地位就可以被主人随便杀害，因为这也是在破坏生产力。董仲舒就曾经提议过对于私杀奴婢的人也必须进行惩罚（《食货志》），从事实来看汉武帝确实接受了这个建议，因为我国最早的将私杀奴婢作为罪行进行惩处的记录就出现在他统治年间（《王子侯表》《建元以来侯者年表》）。当然不能认为这些被官府没收的奴婢都被解放成为了自耕农，实际上《食货志》记载他们大部分都被派去为官府服务了。然而这种对蓄养奴婢公开遏制的态度，毫无疑问对于希望购买奴婢的人是一种威慑。

第二，汉武帝时期的农业生产得到了极大的进步，其标志性的成就便是在中国普及铁器牛耕，同时水利灌溉和种植方法也得到了大幅改善。现在我们已经无法准确地得知汉武帝前后中国农业从亩产上讲具体提升了多少，因为武帝之前的数据是很缺乏的，晁错声称一个成年劳动力可以耕种100汉亩，如果是小亩的话，折合现在14到15市亩。我们从《河渠书》和《货殖列传》中能够通过零散的对于田地的描述得到当时品相良好的土地亩产不超过400斤（但是司马迁也并没有指明具体是什么作物），而在西汉后期的《汜胜之书》中，黍的亩产已经达到470斤。当然汉代各种作物的亩产的确没办法具体考证，不过我们可以从一个非常间接的地方看出当时农业的进步，武帝时期帝国的人口只有3000多万，但是到西汉末年的时候，已经翻了近一番达到了6000万。农业生产力的提高显然有利于小农经济的发展，增强了新兴地主阶级的经济实力。

第三，一个完备成熟的官僚体制能够给予地主阶级更为方便的入仕途径，因而比起一般的古典官僚帝国，西汉帝国可以更快，更大量地吸收地主阶级参与政治决策，这反过来进一步增强了地主阶级的力量。实际上我们可以明显地看到在各个古典帝国中，中国的古典时期其实相当短，从汉武帝基本确定制度，到东汉中期封建庄园就已经在全国极为盛行了，那个时候仅仅过去了两个世纪，而到东汉晚期封建关系已经十分普遍（但是不成熟），地方大员的掾属称自己的上司为“主公”，这也仅仅过了300年。如此快速的过渡是罗马、波斯等国远不能比的。然而正是因为中国的地主阶级没有经过残酷的斗争就如此轻而易举地登上了历史舞台，这必然会造成一种软弱性、妥协性和思想上的惯性，最终作为一个原因导致中国虽然最早走向封建化的赛道，但是却永远也没有走到头。

在这里人们肯定还会怀疑把古典帝国定义成奴隶制国家（如果合适的话）向封建国家过渡的政治体制是否合理，毕竟只有在中国的文献中才有相当明确的证据。关于这个问题，我认为一方面是我国前封建化时期历史文献相对于世界其他地方同期存量非常丰富，在世界其他地方可能也存在同一种现象，但是没有记载下来或者亡佚了。另一个方面是这种过渡之所以在中国变得十分明显，而在其他地方可能本身就不是这么显著，这种差异有其原因，在接下来不同部分我会分别提到，并且在第十二章集中说明。

就这样，古典帝国的普遍性成因已经给出，关于武帝时期内朝的性质也进行了拨乱。与此同时我却愈发担心起来，我越来越感受到中国的历史中充满了谎言，而且谎言是如此普遍地出现在对人民的教育中。如果这些谎言是无意的，那么我们国家过去千百年的史学都研究了什么？如果有些谎言是有意的，那么情况就更可怕了，是谁要掩盖什么东西？我的好友H对此却不以为然，毕竟不受监督的政府做出什么恶行都不值得奇怪。但是在11月底我的忧虑确实加深了，而且这种忧虑即将变为现实。